

Joy as Suspension of Evaluative Optimization

M-ZRT Protocol

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First, thank you for your interest in the method. I simply discovered that when you stop an action at the last moment, without checking or evaluating, joy tends to increase. From this, I developed both a theory and a protocol, M-ZRT, for Morin Z-Reduction Task, with Z referring to evaluation.

The exercises are very simple and can be done in real life (IRL) or in a basic first-person shooter:

Ask yourself a question internally, but do not answer it.

Make a random movement or gesture.

Do not finish a sentence you are thinking about.

Deviate trajectory: while running -> a tiny deviation instead of a perfect line (FPS)

Read one paragraph, then a paragraph from another chapter.

While walking, sometimes slow down (IRL) or stop (IRL, FPS) and continue

Drink a sip of coffee, as it may increase stimulation without increasing evaluation, which is good (appendix).

You can do these exercises in real life, but they may be even more effective in an old futuristic FPS. These games are full of lights, geometric shapes, and environments that are not heavily over-optimized around metrics. It brings stimulation without evaluation, in the same spirit as coffee.

The main trap and its solution

The main trap across these exercises is that they may become performance tasks or objects of evaluation. Therefore, the following idea is to try an exercise a few times, identify where control, optimization, or monitoring appears, and then retry. The goal is to understand what suspending control means in practice and what type of remaining control you want to relax.

For example, if you choose the exercise “ask yourself a question internally, but do not answer it”, you do it a few times, IRL or inside a FPS at low level difficulty. Then you pause and check the corresponding potential failure section, and you resume.

Potential Failures

Ask yourself a question internally, but do not answer it.

Recruit answer:

Many questions automatically recruit answer generation. Even "What if I turned left?" can trigger simulation, pros/cons, or prediction.

Meta-monitoring:

You may start checking whether you successfully avoided answering. Then the exercise becomes a performance evaluation.

Question collection:

The brain may start generating many questions because the exercise itself becomes a search task, "find a good incomplete question."

Repetition ritualization

Reusing the same question format repeatedly can create ritualization. For example, always using spatial questions.

Open loop persistence:

Some questions remain active and continue occupying working memory after the moment ends.

Goal contamination:

The question becomes instrumentalized, "this question will lower control."

Make a random movement or gesture**Ritualization:**

Micro-movements are small, repeatable, and controllable. That makes them highly compressible cognitively. The system can quickly transform: "a small purposeless movement" into: "the movement that might open something." Then repetition begins: same shoulder motion, same mouse adjustment, same head tilt, same timing. The movement becomes a ritualized trigger attempt.

Internal monitoring:

The player may begin checking internal effects immediately after the movement. Examples: "Did something shift?" "Was that lighter?" "Did perception change?" "Should I do another one?" Now the movement is linked to evaluation loops. The movement itself is usually not the issue. The post-movement checking is.

Agency inflation:

A major danger is developing the feeling: "I can produce the state manually." This increases instrumental control. The movement becomes a lever. Then the brain starts optimizing: timing, intensity, frequency, context, precision. That raises Z strongly because the system enters causal manipulation mode.

Artificial randomness:

Many people try to protect against ritualization by making movements "random." But deliberate randomness is often still an optimization. The system starts generating controlled unpredictability: "Now I'll randomly move left." "I'll intentionally break patterns." "I'll surprise myself." This can become hyper-controlled anti-control.

Escalation:

Tiny movements can progressively become larger or more frequent because of adaptation. The system may start thinking: "That small movement stopped working." "I need stronger deviations." "I need novelty." Then the exercise becomes stimulation-seeking.

State attribution:

If a positive shift happens after a micro-movement, the brain may falsely assign causality to the exact action. Then the movement gains symbolic power. After that, absence of the movement may even feel "wrong," which is the opposite of low crystallization. The safest version of micro-movement is usually: brief, non-special, non-repeated, non-verified, non-optimized, and quickly forgotten.

Do not finish a sentence you are thinking about.

Completion monitoring

The brain immediately asks: did I leave it unfinished? Did I accidentally finish it? how long should it remain incomplete? Now incompleteness itself becomes monitored.

Reactivation Unfinished cognitive objects often attract reactivation. Instead of disappearing, the sentence may persist: “what was I going to say?” The exercise accidentally creates stickiness.

Deliberate sentence construction

A dangerous drift: Step 1: invent sentence Step 2: interrupt sentence Step 3: maintain incompleteness, and now the exercise is fully procedural.

Internal language overload

Because the exercise is linguistic, it can recruit: semantic processing, self-talk, rehearsal. This is riskier than brief motor perturbations because language is easier to stabilize into rules. Short sensorimotor actions often resist crystallization better than internally narrated exercises.

Turning uncertainty into content

The unfinished sentence can become: “What if...” or: “Maybe I should...” Then you accidentally create planning loops.

Completion pressure

Humans strongly dislike unfinished structures. The urge to close the sentence may itself become salient.

Repetition effects

Repeated use may create templates: “maybe...” “what if...” “I should...” Then the exercise becomes formulaic.

Meta-monitoring

Common hidden loop: “Was that unresolved enough?” This is probably the fastest route toward crystallization.

Narrative generation

The sentence can become meaningful. Example: “Maybe later I could...” Now there is a future-oriented object.

Hidden task creation

The exercise can silently become: “practice incompleteness.” Once it has a training objective, monitoring increases

Deviate trajectory: while running, a tiny curve instead of a perfect line.

Trajectory monitoring

The brain starts checking: curved enough? too straight? too large? Then movement geometry becomes explicit. The deviation should remain almost too small to evaluate.

Over-scaling

Tiny curve becomes: large detour, zig-zagging, exaggerated movement. Bigger perturbations are easier to notice and ritualize.

Timing rules

You may unconsciously create: every corridor, every 30 seconds, before corners. Then deviation becomes scheduled.

Reverse optimization

A subtle failure mode: “avoid straight lines.” That is still optimization. Just with different rules.

Spatial self-consciousness

Movement may become something you observe instead of something you do. That increases monitoring.

Becoming a signature movement

A repeated curve pattern can become: your movement style. Then it stops being perturbation.

Goal contamination

You may begin using deviation strategically: scouting, visibility, exploration. Now the perturbation gained utility.

Internal narration

Dangerous versions: “I interrupt optimization.” “I break efficiency.” These create semantic weight. Short sensorimotor framing usually crystallizes less.

Visual fixation

You might begin watching the curve itself. Then the trajectory becomes an object.

Achievement feeling

“I successfully disrupted my movement.” Success metrics increase monitoring.

While walking, sometimes slow down or stop for a few seconds

Speed monitoring

The brain quickly asks: slow enough? too slow? noticeable? for how long? Now speed or pause becomes measured.

Pace ritualization

Very common drift: slow down/pause every corner, slow down/pause when stressed, slow down at transitions. Then it becomes scheduled.

Anti-efficiency optimization

This exercise is especially vulnerable to inversion: normal optimization: maximize efficiency. failure mode: minimize efficiency. Still optimization.

Identity formation

Repeated use can become: “I am the person who intentionally slows down or pause” That gives the action narrative weight.

Social monitoring

It is public. Thoughts like: “do I look strange?” can recruit self-evaluation.

Expansion creep

A slight slowdown slowly becomes: much slower, prolonged slowing, slower walking style. Small perturbations tend to survive better than global changes.

Converting movement into observation

You may start paying attention to: cadence, foot placement, body feeling, timing. Now locomotion becomes an object.

Transition contamination

The slowdown may recruit decision moments: “what next?” This is why continuous movement often preserves flow better than explicit pauses.

Success criteria formation

You may start thinking: “I successfully interrupted efficiency.” Once success exists, evaluation enters.

Becomes a technique

The danger is not slowing down. The danger is using slowing down. Previous patterns point in the same direction: short sensorimotor perturbations that remain integrated into action tend to crystallize less than explicit procedures or pauses.

Exercise: Drink a Sip of Coffee

Sensory monitoring

Coffee has a strong: taste, temperature, anticipation, and body effects. The brain can immediately ask: did it feel different? stronger? enjoyable? Activating? Now the sip becomes measured. (It’s why we want just a sip)

Reward anticipation

Coffee already has learned value. A sip may trigger: anticipation > monitoring > expectation. The risk is not the sip itself. It is the predictive machinery around it.

Turning the sip into a marker

Example drift: sip before task, sip during stress, sip when doing exercises. Then coffee becomes a trigger.

Micro-ritual formation

Very easy failure mode: “one intentional sip.” Tiny repeated actions ritualize fast.

Sensory extraction

The sip can become: taste observation. Then: coffee → object of attention.

Caffeine attribution

Later effects may get attached to the sip. That increases salience of future sips.

Completion pressure

People often naturally want: another sip. One sip can create continuation pull.

Timing optimization

You may start wondering: best moment for sip? wrong moment? too early? Now timing becomes part of the exercise.

Meaning inflation

A sip can become: “the intervention.” This creates symbolic load.

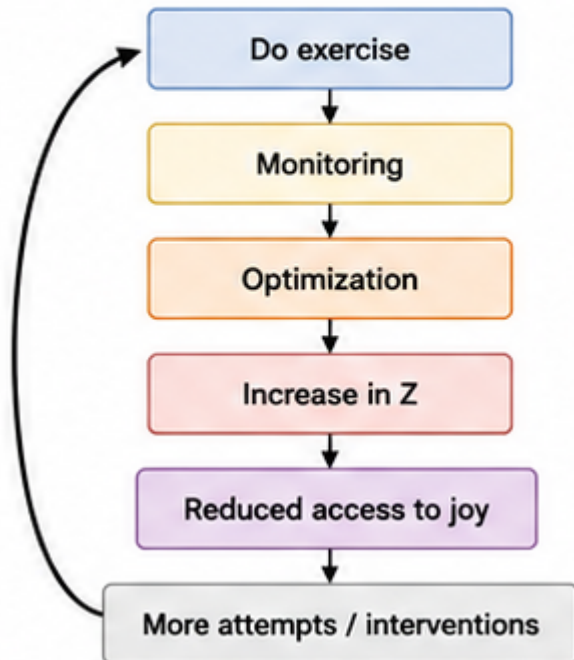
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Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, <https://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

Appendix

THE SELF-BLOCKING LOOP

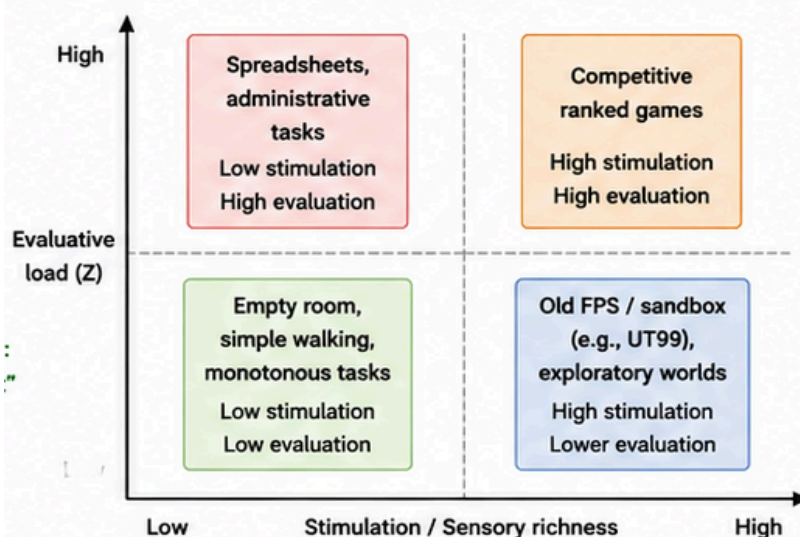
Why exercises often backfire



Each exercise includes failure points because interventions themselves can become self-blocking. Identifying how an exercise drifts into monitoring, optimization, or evaluative control helps detect when the procedure itself starts increasing Z .

ENVIRONMENTS: STIMULATION vs EVALUATION

Why old FPS / non-optimized worlds are useful



Ideal zone: high stimulation with lower evaluative load.
Provides stimulation without strong evaluation.